

A friend of a friend had arranged for Woodruff to interview at Société Générale in New York. The trader who interviewed him was setting up a desk of proprietary traders and felt that Woodruff's approach would be completely uncorrelated to any of the other traders and therefore a good fit. Woodruff very successfully traded a proprietary account for Société Générale from 1998 until March 2000. He found that not having to deal with the business side was a great advantage in that it allowed him the time to continue his research. It was during his time at Société Générale that Woodruff first applied and began using his systematic style of trading for a long/short equity account, which was the precursor to his firm's equity trading program.

Woodruff left Société Générale because his boss, Jonathan, was leaving to start a multimanager hedge fund operation and had invited Woodruff to join him. Jonathan had told Woodruff that three other portfolio managers would be part of the group. One of these managers had worked for George Soros and Paul Tudor Jones and was a familiar name to Woodruff. Woodruff was excited about being part of an elite trading group. In preparation for the new venture, several months earlier, Woodruff had asked Michael Geismar, a former roommate who had also worked for him at Blue Ridge, to come to New York to work as his right-hand man. Geismar prepared a trading operation. Shortly after Woodruff left Société Générale, Woodruff began trading a proprietary equity account using his system, while waiting for the hedge fund operation to launch.

Woodruff attended a meeting to discuss setting up the new multimanager fund and was surprised that he was the only one to show up besides Jonathan. When he told Geismar about the meeting, Geismar said, "You've got to meet these other managers."

At the next meeting, Woodruff again found that he was the only other manager there. "Jonathan, where is everyone else?" he asked.

Jonathan replied, "Well, I have been working really hard to get everyone, but I'm afraid that it is just you and me."

Woodruff, who had anticipated this possibility, answered, "I'm sorry Jonathan, it's just you."

Woodruff had gotten off to an extremely good start with his proprietary equity account, and after the hedge fund plan fell through, his intention was